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THE HINDU



An all-night cultural festival at Alliance Francaise explores comic books as muses **P2**

ALL ABOUT BHARATHBALA'S FASCINATING DOCUMENTARY P4















Time travel (Clockwise from left) Ebenezer Sunder Singh (right) with AP Santhanaraj; student groups from across the decades; with KCS Paniker seated at the centre; S Dhanapal at work on a sculpture; a craft workshop in 1902; SG Vasudev (extreme right) in 1965. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

As Government College of Fine Arts completes 175 years, its alumni returns to reflect on the classrooms, teachers, and friendships that shaped generations of artists

Swatches of a living legacy

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As I step into the Government College of Fine Arts, Egmore, on a bright morning this October, it is not the college's familiar red facade that catches my eye, but the sculptures scattered across its sprawling campus. Many of these that take the intriguing form of human bodies, have stood here for decades, perhaps even as long as the institution itself, and its generations of students.

Today, they have become reminders of the young artists who once walked these corridors, worked in the studios, and eventually left their mark on the world's infinitely large art landscape.

With the college marking its 175th anniversary celebrations on October 3, we look back not only at the history that shaped the institution, but also at the people, memories, and stories that have given this historic campus its character.

Painting the past

For nearly eight decades after its founding in 1850, the Madras School of Arts was defined strictly by craft. Under EB Havell, who joined as the superintendent in 1884, the curriculum was entirely focussed on industrial crafts workshops. By the late 1920s, a severe gap was felt: the institution was churning out skilled craftsmen, but not a single fine artist. That changed in 1929 when Bengali sculptor Devi Prasad Roy Choudhury was hired as the school's first artist-principal. Roy Choudhury introduced a formal curriculum focussed on the subject and divided it into two streams: painting and modelling (sculpture). Prior to his arrival, many students (often sons of artisans receiving stipends) remained for up to 10 years without graduating. Roy Choudhury streamlined the programme, which led to the school's first crop of fine artists in the watershed year of 1935.

"When Roy Choudhury took over as the first Indian principal, he brought in the academic curriculum set forth by famous painters like Nandalal Bose, Abanindranath Tagore, and EB Havell in Calcutta. Choudhury was able to bring forward a certain formal training in painting and drawing, or what we call the Fine Arts programme, which is different from the Industrial Arts programme and the Commercial Arts programme, which also happened at the college at the time," says Ashvin E Rajagopalan, director, Ashvita's, a gallery in Chennai.

Alumnus G Raman from the 1959 batch still recalls Roy Choudhury's influence. "He was a teacher we all looked up to. He would never simply pass by a student – he would stop,



look at their work, and sometimes even draw something to show us," says Raman.

"The first thing that he did was to throw out the antiquated models previously used for teaching anatomy and body figures, replacing them with live models. He successfully implemented these changes because any suggestion made was immediately accepted by the Department of Public Instruction," says art historian, and art critic Ashrafi S Bhagat.

KCS Paniker and S Dhanapal, joined the institution as students and graduated circa 1940. Roy Choudhury gave them both a teacher's job at the institution: Dhanapal for Sculpture, and Paniker for Painting. Paniker's role in the institution was crucial, as he stepped into the role of Principal in 1957 after Roy Choudhury's retirement.

"Paniker was the Principal when I was in college," says artist P Gopinath, one of the last masters of the Cholamandal Artists Village, an artists' commune on the East Coast Road. Instead of following a master or teacher, Paniker (a pioneer of the Madras Art Movement, a modernist movement that was born in Chennai in the 1960s), was keen that students develop and learn a critical grammar to suit their own way of expression, he says. "Because of that, many students were able to participate in exhibitions like the Paris Biennale and Sau Paolo Biennale. The college had no hierarchy," says Gopinath.

"He would start discussing the artists, talking about their works and showing them pictures and paintings by the Impressionists, Post-Impressionists, Cubists, and Abstract Expressionists. They saw works by Van Gogh and many others, and those discussions opened a whole new world of art for them," says Ashrafi.

Many masters

It was not just Paniker but also his colleagues, along with Dhanapal, eminent artists like R Krishna Rao, CJ Anthony Doss, L Munuswamy, and AP Santhanaraj, and Alphonso Arul Doss who were able to not only efficiently administer the school but also take painting exhibitions by Madras artists to Delhi and Mumbai.



Maruthappan Marudu aka Trotsky Marudu, who served as the art director and VFX creative director of many Tamil films like *Rajakali Amman, Palayathu Amman, and Nandalala,* says that the 1970s were the golden period for art in Tamil Nadu. "We used to have film screenings and theatre workshops. There were also some experimental films. I remember seeing films by Norman McLaren, since I have always been very interested in animation," he adds.

At a time when the art space was dominated by mostly men, artist Asma Menon says, the college also gave her a fresh breath of independence.

"I was the only woman in the first batch of the degree course." The wonderful thing about her five years of college was the complete artistic freedom. "We could walk out of class, sit in the garden and sketch. If we wanted to take a break, we could go out, and sketch a bit. There was no major discipline in terms of pushing the boundaries of our creativity," she says. "I would be the only girl among six or seven boys. We would sit at the tea shop, have tea, and butter biscuit, and smoke *beedis*. At that time, it didn't matter," she adds.

The college library was essential to New York-based artist Ebenezer Sunder Singh. "The first time I read about [Russian painter] Wassily Kandinsky was from a book I found there. Then there was [Swiss-German artist] Paul Klee's book *Pedagogical Sketchbooks*. These were eye-openers because, you didn't really know what was happening in the West or what you were actually learning."

Over the decades, the college's identity and name changed from being the Madras School of Arts and Crafts, the Government School of Arts and Crafts, the Government College of Arts and Crafts and, in 2001, finally the Government College of Fine Arts. "The change itself says that the institution's very existence has guided various art movements in the city," says Ashvin.

By early 2000, the college had introduced new courses including the MFA (Master of Fine Arts). For artist Ezhilarasan Ezhumale who graduated in 2005, studying was more participatory. "During our time, professors G Chandrasekaran and KT Gandhirajan were teaching. They were involved in anthropology and history as well. They were the ones who discovered the Karikiyoor site rock art in the Nilgiris. There was rock art dating back around 3,000 years. We had the opportunity to go there and do fieldwork. There were many such opportunities available to us." The new direction continued to hold the students' interest.

It still does as the college steps into its 176th year. With unfailing consistency, it becomes evident that the story about a single artistic language of several generations that have passed through its studios, classrooms and gardens, seems to emerge. The steady presence of the red-brick structure at the borders of Elumbur, proves that art persists as much as it evolves.

STEPOUT



Building hope

The *Wall of Hope*, a youth-led initiative by SCARF's Department of Youth Mental Health at IIT Madras Research Park, brought together more than 20,000 post-it notes carrying young people's everyday joys. Built over a year through schools, and colleges, the project aimed to make conversations around hope, distress and help-seeking more open, while giving young people space to define what keeps them going. *This is an ongoing initiative.*



A musical confluence

Goethe-Institut Chennai will host Mulberry Quintet, bringing together German and Western classical music with Indian composition. The five-member string ensemble will present works by Carl Stamitz, JS Bach, WA Mozart, Ludwig van Beethoven and Johannes Brahms, alongside Indian compositions specially arranged for a string quintet. *@Goethe Institute, Nungambakkam. October 16, 6.30pm. For passes, call 28331314.*



Crafting community

Porgai, a collective of 60 Lambadi women from Sittlingi Valley in Dharmapuri, brings its distinctive embroidery tradition to Chennai. Known for its embroidery on garments and home furnishings, the collective has also explored tapestries and art work. Alongside the exhibition, Paarvai, the 10th anniversary exhibition of Art on the Terrace will be inaugurated. *@Art on the Terrace, Besant Nagar, October 10 and 11, 10am to 8pm. For details, call 9840357567.*



Tradition's ways

Explore diverse art forms from across India and the tales behind them at an art exhibition hosted by Chennai's InKo Centre



Eternal grace Kerala mural exhibited at InKo Centre. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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From afar, Warli paintings, holding up 2,500 years of tradition, resemble a red canvas filled with white geometric shapes. Look closer, and the lines and triangles reveal stories, mostly of Nature and social rituals of Maharashtra's Warli tribe.

Hunters praying to spirits before setting out for the day, rivers filled with fish flowing through forests, and thadpa (performed by the Warli tribe) dancers depicted in circular formations, are some of the recurring themes observable in Warli artist Anil Chaitya Vangad's paintings displayed at an exhibition, Traversing the Tapestry, at Chennai's InKo Centre.

The display includes a collection of artworks curated by art enthusiast Ritu Bandari. The exhibition also screens a documentary on her 14-month-long journey researching 12 art forms from different stretches of the country as well as conversations with the artists.

Among the paintings, pattachitra – an artwork made of a natural palette that includes colours such as red, yellow, and blue from sindoor, haldi, and aprajita flower– from Odisha and West Bengal by artist Swarna Chitrakar stands out. "These paintings include stories of Radha and Krishna from Hindu mythology and a famous folk narrative of the wedding of the fish," says Ritu.

Vijay Joshi's phad, Anwar Citrakar's Kalighat paintings from Kolkata, KU Krishnakumar's Kerala mural art, and Rajaram Sharma's pichwai paintings from Rajasthan also draw attention at the exhibit.

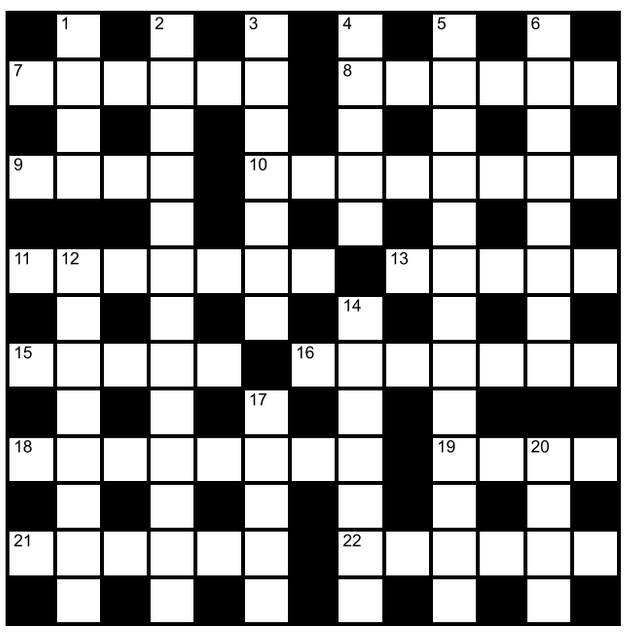
"One of the things that concerns me is the imbalance of knowledge and power. A community may possess a design language or technique that has evolved over hundreds of years, while someone from outside can come, reinterpret it and take it into a larger commercial market," Ritu says, as she speaks about the importance of who benefits financially and who retains ownership of the knowledge while engaging with art.

"Once we understand the person, the knowledge behind the object, we don't just buy a product, but we become participants in keeping a living tradition alive," she adds.

The exhibition is open on all days from 10am to 6pm except Sundays and public holidays till October 23 at InKo Centre.

METROPLUS QUICK CROSSWORD #74

(Set by Doppelganger)



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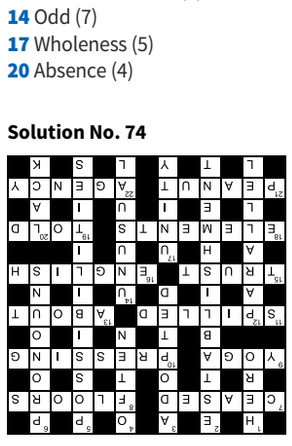
Across

7 Stopped (6)
8 Levels (6)
9 Ancient Indian discipline (4)
10 Ironing (8)
11 Unintentionally dropped (7)
13 Approximately (5)
15 Firm belief (5)
16 One of the world's most popular languages (7)
18 Members of a set (8)
19 Conveyed information to someone (4)
21 Edible seed that is a popular snack (6)
22 Administrative division (6)

Down

1 Principal character in a movie (4)
2 Business organisation (13)
3 Accepted or established something in a formal way (7)
4 Regularly (5)
5 Chances (13)
6 Function words (8)
12 Characteristic of two lines that never intersect (8)
14 Odd (7)
17 Wholeness (5)
20 Absence (4)

Solution No. 74





Culinary canvas (Clockwise from right) The Udupi thali served at Matsya, Udipi Home in Egmore; (below) Ram Bhat. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

A taste of Udupi, 76 years on

Seventy-six years since it began, Chennai's Matsya Restaurant is returning to its Udupi roots, reviving heritage dishes alongside its much-loved midnight fare and filter coffee

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One sunny afternoon in October, we step into Matsya Restaurant, where the cosy interiors and friendly staff immediately make us feel at home. We order our favourites from the menu – items that have not changed in years – *rasa vada* and chilli cheese toast.

As we wait for our order, Ram Bhat, a partner in the family-run establishment, walks in.

The establishment marks 76 years since its beginnings as an Udupi home and on the occasion the family running the restaurant looks back at its roots and bring its heritage menu back into focus. "We want the current generation to enjoy the Udupi fare that we are known for," says Ram, before insisting that we try their *ven pongal* served with fruit *pachadi*.

The combination does not particularly appeal to me at first, but I end up relishing the rather unusual pairing. "This is typical Udupi style. The fruit pachadi is made using fresh curd, and it is beaten with sugar. A mix of cut fruits is then added and served along with steaming-hot pongal," he explains. The restaurant is also introducing tomato uthappam and apple bajji as part of its renewed focus on traditional offerings.

These new dishes make us wonder what Matsya might have looked like when it first began. What is its origin story? Ram Bhat answers.





Humble beginnings

Matsya's history began long before the restaurant acquired its present name. It was originally known as Udupi Home, launched in 1950 by Ram's father's elder brother Shaama Bhat. In 1980, his younger brother, Hari Bhat, rebranded the restaurant as Matsya, while retaining the 'Udupi Home' name for the boarding and lodging facility.

"My uncle started Udupi Home soon after Independence. Our USP was its proximity to Egmore Railway Station, as well as several major hospitals and Government offices, all within a two-kilometre radius. In those days, people from the Udupi and Mangalore regions would come to Chennai and stay at our lodging," recalls Ram.

Over the years, the restaurant gained a loyal following for its vegetarian fare rooted in the culinary traditions of Udupi.

In 1962, during the India-China war, frequent blackouts were imposed across the city. It was during this period that the restaurant began serving food well past midnight – a tradition that continues to this day.

"We started serving idlis and filter coffee until 2am in those days, and the tradition continues even today. On our midnight menu, the most popular items are chilli cheese toast, bread peas masala, Udupi-style *dosa*, and filter coffee," says Ram. As lifestyles changed, so did the late-night clientele. "We cater to those who go clubbing until the wee hours and also those who walk in after watching late-night film shows," he adds.

Interestingly, Matsya has several feathers in its cap. It was among the early restaurants in the city to have a separate air-conditioned section, and by 1992, the entire restaurant had been air-conditioned. When Hari Bhat launched Matsya in 1980, he commissioned architect K Ramanan, who had designed Adyar Gate Hotel, later known as Crowne Plaza, to design the restaurant.

"It was the city's elite who patronised us. The late Tamil Nadu Chief Minister MG Ramachandran would often order badam kheer from our kitchen whenever he hosted a party at his residence. RM Veerappan (politician), actor Nagesh, Cho Ramaswamy (political commentator and actor) and several other politicians also frequented the restaurant," says Ram.

What's changed?

When Ram took over the running of the restaurant in 1992, he revamped the menu to cater to a younger audience and the growing number of office-goers who began dropping in for lunch.

"We introduced dishes from the tandoor based on popular demand. I also launched the cold coffee, falooda and the Udupi thali, as I wanted to showcase the regional cuisine of the place I hail from, which is Dandathirtha near Udupi, and we also have lands in Moodibidri near Putthige. In those days, an authentic Udupi thali was a rarity, and that was when our *rasa vada* became a rage among regular customers," says Ram.

The restaurant's food has also found a wide audience since the pandemic, particularly its *rasam*. "During the lockdown and the pandemic, we made gallons and gallons of *rasam*. While we would normally prepare two cauldrons of rasam a day, during the pandemic years we were preparing six cauldrons," says Ram.

Back to the basics

Today, Matsya is once again looking towards its heritage. The focus is on bringing traditional Udupi fare to the forefront and introducing diners to dishes that may not be as familiar as the ubiquitous dosa, Mangalore buns, and goli baje.

The menu now highlights specialities such as *ragi dosa, jowar dosa,* and *thatte idli*, alongside the more familiar Udupi favourites. The dessert selection, too, draws from the traditional recipes of Udupi and coastal Karnataka.

"We have continued the Udupi legacy for three generations and hope to carry the tradition forward. Some of the Udupi snacks that were served only between 3pm and 7pm will now be available from noon to 7pm. We have been adapting and changing our menu to suit the generations we cater to, but Udupi fare will remain the highlight," says Ram.

After 75 years, Matsya may have changed with its customers, its city and its times. But at its heart, the restaurant remains what it set out to be – a place where the flavours of Udupi have found a lasting home in Chennai.



Arts abound Scenes from the previous edition of La Nuit Blanche with the theme *Moulin Rouge*. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Drawn to the night

The fourth edition of La Nuit Blanche, an all-night festival, brings French and Indian traditions together with theatre, dance, music, exhibitions and more

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For one night this October, Tintin and Snowy will find themselves in the company of Suppandi and Tenali Raman in Chennai. Speech bubbles will creep across walls, familiar comic-book characters will appear larger than life, and stories usually contained within neat rectangular panels will spill into music, theatre, dance, and performance.

Alliance Francaise of Madras' (AFM) annual all-night arts festival, La Nuit Blanche, returns for its fourth edition on October 10, this time turning its attention to the world of comics. Titled La Nuit de la Bande Dessinée (The Night of Comics) the festival brings French and Indian comic traditions together across 13 hours of performance.

"This is the fourth edition. The event has gained a lot of popularity in the city so audience expect a certain standard. We want to ensure that quality is not misplaced. Patricia (former director of AFM) contributed to it until the day she left, and we are not leaving any story unturned," says TK Durgaprasad, president, AFM.

The six spaces at AFM will take on different facets of the comic-book world, with more than 30 events unfolding across the afternoon, evening, and into the early hours of October 11.

The auditorium will host theatre, readings, and music. The programming will begin with Matinee Show Maamé, an afternoon of short comedies by English and French theatre group Theatre Arlequin. Among the highlights is Detectives! Desire! Death rays! Draw!, a bilingual live reading of Tamil pulp fiction by Blaft Publications' founders Rashmi RD and Nirmal Rajagopalan bringing the stories to voice while watercolour artist Shyam Sankar illustrates them in real time. Pianist Adam Greig will pair a live performance with a display of classic French etchings and caricatures in Hearing the Frame.

The library will be the more hands-on corner of the festival, with the focus shifting to how stories are drawn, read and pieced together. Khushi Bansal of Bengaluru's Museum of Art & Photography will present their show A Moving Line: A History of Sequential Storytelling in India, while visitors can try their hand at making comics through Bhavya Desai's Life in Basic Shapes workshop and an illustration workshop by M Karthikeyan.

In the atrium, comics make way for Tamil Nadu's performance traditions, with devarattam by Kalaimamani Kumararaman's troupe; kailasa vadhyam by Aadhimudhalon Sivaboothaganangal, and a leather puppet show by Kalaivanar Tholpavai Koothu Kalaikuzhu. The Tamil Jazz Collective will bring a contemporary note to the space with its Carnatic jazz performance.

At ESPACE24, the exhibition Drawn to India looks beyond the familiar comic book to trace India's long history of visual storytelling. The exhibition travels from temple walls and painted scrolls to comics, graphic novels and webcomics, placing contemporary sequential art within a much older tradition of telling stories through images. The space will also screen five French films with English subtitles through the night.

For a musical evening, head to the terrace. The line-up moves from a student-led acappella performance by Cleftomaniacs, to jazz and blues by KIN Band. With workshops, exhibitions, screenings, dance and music spread across the campus, La Nuit Blanche has grown into an important fixture in Chennai's cultural calendar, bringing together audiences and art forms that might not otherwise share the same space.

La Nuit Blanche 2026 will be held on October 10 from 2pm to October 11, 3am at Alliance Française of Madras. Entry is free and open to all. For the full schedule, log on to afmadras on Instagram.

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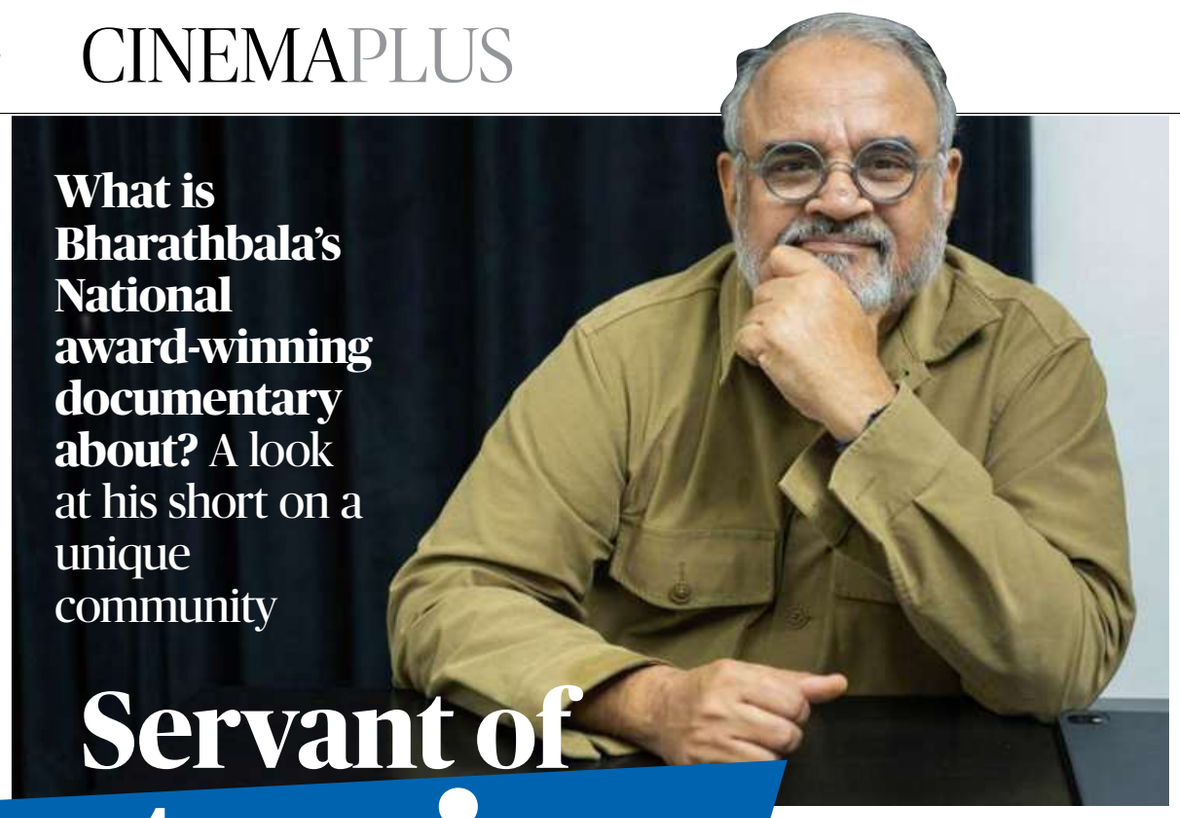
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What is Bharathbala's National award-winning documentary about? A look at his short on a unique community

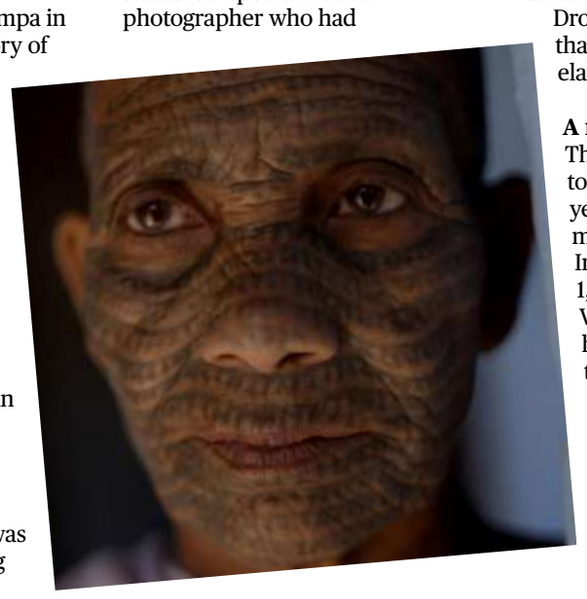
Servant of stories

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The story of this National award begins with one photograph.

Five years ago, Chennai-based filmmaker Bharatbala travelled to Champa in Chattisgarh, chasing the story of the Ramnami community, an ostracised devotional Hindu sect founded in the 1890s. Back in the 19th Century, they were barred from entering temples because of their caste. As a form of peaceful protest, they decided to immerse their bodies in streaks of carefully placed Sanskrit lettering spelling out the word 'Ram', a god in India in whose name miracles and unspeakable horrors alike, have been committed over the years.

Bharatbala says that he was not interested in politicising or marketing Ram when he first heard about the community. "Ram can market himself," he says. Instead, he wanted to capture the tale of this community reeling from years of untouchability and a riveting history. "I was visiting my father-in-law in Auroville and stumbled upon a French photographer who had travelled around India. One of his images was of the Ramnami," he says. The journey led him straight to Champa where the filmmaker travelled with a lean crew of about six to seven members and spent about 15 days trying to understand the Ramnamis who continue to tattoo themselves head to toe as a form of penance.

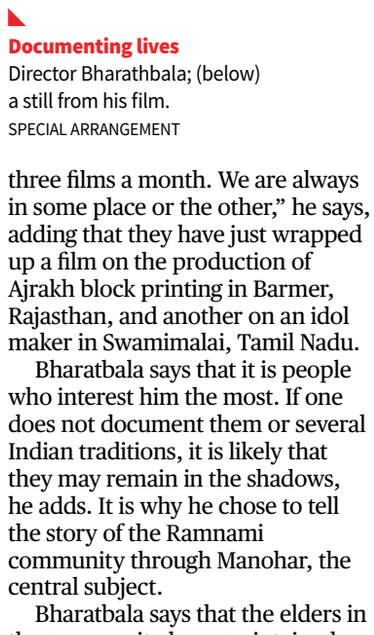


In six minutes, the filmmaker seemed to capture several people's imaginations. *Ramnami* won the Best Documentary award at the 72nd National Film Award on September 22. Bharatbala received the honour from President Droupadi Murmu, and added that this was a moment of elation.

A mind of one's own

This moment is not unfamiliar to the filmmaker though. In the years that Bharatbala has spent making 124 films to study India's vast culture through a 1,000-film odyssey called Virtual Bharat, he seems to have achieved elation. "I feel the youngest now," he laughs. "It's a volcano of love, excitement and creativity. Suddenly, I am a man in a hurry, because there is so much more to do."

The pace has been relentless. "We are making three films a month. We are always in some place or the other," he says, adding that they have just wrapped up a film on the production of Ajrakh block printing in Barmer, Rajasthan, and another on an idol maker in Swamimalai, Tamil Nadu.



Documenting lives
Director Bharathbala; (below) a still from his film.
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Bharatbala says that it is people who interest him the most. If one does not document them or several Indian traditions, it is likely that they may remain in the shadows, he adds. It is why he chose to tell the story of the Ramnami community through Manohar, the central subject.

Bharatbala says that the elders in the community have maintained that they discover the God within. "They don't need to go to the temple. They have found the temple lying within them. For them, this is penance," he adds.

Yet, he also says that he has noticed an important shift. In the last minute of the film, we watch a young child in the community climbing over Manohar. The child remains tattoo-less. "That is where the spirit of the story lies," he says.

Bharatbala is raring to tell many such other tales. He has just completed a feature film on the Maha Kumbh Mela shot in 2025 over 45 days. "The story is about Hindustani classical music, a patriarchal father, and daughters who are taking a legacy forward," he says. Legendary music composer AR Rahman, who has worked with the director back in 1997 on the iconic 'Vande Maataram' song and in his 2013 film *Maryan,* has collaborated with him on nine out of 12 tracks, he says.

Has the tireless pace and the film made an impact on him? "I am a changed person. I am liberated," he says. "If you are working for somebody, there is a studio, a producer, financial commitments. We have no such pressure. I am a servant of these stories. Nothing else."

The boy wonder

Who is Sai Prithviraj, the child artiste making waves in Vijay Sethupathi's latest?

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A child cries and expresses all the pain he carries, prompting a hall full of adults to hoot and applaud the boy's performance.

Director Balaji Tharaneetharan's latest film, *Baththa*, starring Vijay Sethupathi, had a little surprise in store for audiences. Though the makers consciously promoted the film as a gangster drama, *Baththa* had a mature story about repression and the masks we wear, told from a child's perspective.

Child actor Sai Prithviraj, who played the film's protagonist, Sabari, feels over the moon to see the reception the film has been garnering. He is eager to see what his friends at school would say. "I have been busy with the promotions. So I haven't called my friends, and neither have they called me yet. But I think they will tell me when I go to school next," he tells us.

Sai developed an interest in acting after watching his sister, Kayal, an actor who worked in Vijay Antony's *Maargan*. "My sister taught me acting, and I started liking it. So when I got the opportunity to do *Baththa*, I asked her to teach me after school hours," says Sai.

Working in *Baththa*, he says, was a jolly experience. Sabari might have been a nervous little boy in the film, but not Sai. "I was never afraid," he says.

Director Balaji, whose films Sai admires, did not explain much about the story of *Baththa*. "He just told me that I need to play Sabari." However, Sai is grateful for how "slow and steady" Balaji was on set. "I liked how correctly he explained what I had to do."

Vijay Sethupathi, too, offered his help during the scene, he adds. Working with the star was a jolly good experience for Sai. "I gained a lot of experience in acting because of him. He said I performed superbly; he kept repeating that education is important and I should focus on studies as well," says Sai.



Sai Prithviraj and Vijay Sethupathi in a still from *Baththa*. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Up next, Sai, whose acting role model is former actor and Tamil Nadu Chief Minister Vijay, will be seen alongside Dhanush in the star's 56th film, directed by Tamizharasan Pachamuthu of *Lubber Pandhu* fame.

